REGIONS, LEGIONS

The wheels of the polity can't choose between hub and spoke, even if **the Centre has historically viewed states with wariness.** The record is quite clear. Federalism is key: their proximity to the ground means states score on both policy innovation and democratic dialogue–making challenge now is to become

By ***Amarnath K. Menon***



The late N.T. Rama Rao once described the Centre as "a myth". That was peak federalism, if you will. It's a spirit that flourishes in India, if you take the swelling in the number of states as the distinct metric. From the 17 provinces and 565 princely states that came together to form the Indian Union, a total of 14 states and six Union Territories (UTs) were formed following the Reorganisation of States in 1956. Agitations for separate statehood increased the count to 29 states and seven UTs by 2014. Now, after the bifurcation of Jammu and Kashmir, there have been 28 states and eight UTs since October 2019.

Beyond boundaries and demographics, in electoral and governance terms, federalism has inspired a transition from single-party rule to that by alliances. As democratic theorists have long argued, the doctrine of fiscal and administrative centralisation, pursued vigorously by successive governments in New Delhi, is built on specious arguments. It ignores the contention that an effective, efficient Union of States—and indeed, growth—can only emerge out of robust federalism, built around sustained societal deliberations.

The National Development Council (NDC), a unique platform that brings together all states and UTs, has failed the onus of creating a real debate here. On balance, states have been better at promoting inclusive growth—the uniform spread of health, education and poverty reduction—because they are focused on, and alive to, region-specific realities. Being more familiar with the ground, and driven by democratic impulses, they also have a better record of opening social and political spaces for subaltern groups.

Kerala and Tamil Nadu, for instance, have done more to improve the lives of their residents, across communities,



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